

The Longest Silence

He had not played for twelve years. She found the piano in his house after he died, and it was still in tune.

CEFR Level B1

Book 8 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A house in rural Wales. London. A music conservatoire.

Genre: Music / Grief / Family

Characters

- Iris — 29. Cellist. Daughter of a pianist who stopped playing twelve years ago.
- Martin — Her father. Dead. Present through the piano and what people say about him.
- Vera — 68. Martin's former colleague. A pianist and teacher at the Royal Academy.
- The piano — a Steinway, still in tune after twelve years of silence.

She had always known there was a piano in her father's house.

She had played it herself as a child — not well, and not for long. She was a cellist, like her mother had been.

Her father was a pianist. Had been, until twelve years ago. After her mother's death, he had stopped.

He had not explained why, and Iris had not asked — not because she didn't want to know, but because she had sensed, even at seventeen, that the silence around the piano was a weight he was carrying in a particular way, and that asking would not lighten it.

He had died three weeks ago. She was standing in his front room, looking at the piano.

Middle C.

It was in tune.

This surprised her. Pianos needed to be tuned regularly — someone had been maintaining this instrument once a year, at least, for twelve years during which it had not been played.

She played a scale. Then she stopped.

She knew that a musician who has stopped playing does not usually maintain their instrument.

She thought: he was keeping it ready.

For what?

In the study — a room she had rarely entered, partly because of the unspoken rules of the house and partly because it seemed to contain a version of her father she didn't quite know — she found the music.

Hundreds of pages. Some printed, some handwritten. Scores for standard repertoire she recognised — Schubert, Chopin, Beethoven.

And scores in her father's handwriting that were not standard repertoire.

She took one of the handwritten scores to the piano. She tried to read it.

It was technically very difficult.

She could not tell whether it was finished.

She found Vera Holbrook's name in her father's address book.

Vera was a pianist and professor at the Royal Academy — emeritus now, but still teaching.

She emailed her. Vera replied the same day.

'I was hoping one of you would contact me. Your father asked me to hold copies of his scores when the time came. I have them. Can we meet?'

Iris read the email twice.

The time came. She had written as if she had been expecting it for years.

Vera was in her late sixties — straight-backed and precise, with the particular quality of attention that Iris recognised from the best teachers she had known.

'Your father sent me copies four years ago,' Vera said. 'He said: when I die, give these to Iris if she asks.'

'If I asked,' Iris repeated.

'Yes. He said he didn't want you to feel obligated. He thought you might not want to know.'

'What are they?' 'Compositions. He wrote for twelve years after he stopped performing.'

Iris stared at her. 'I knew nothing,' she said.

Martin had stopped performing after his wife's death — this was what Iris already knew.

What she hadn't known was that he had not stopped writing.

He had come to Vera six months after the funeral, with the first pieces. He had said: I can't perform. The piano in front of an audience is not possible. But I have to keep writing or I will not be able to do anything.

'Did you try to persuade him to perform again?' 'Yes. Several times. He said no each time with great specificity.'

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Iris finds her father's piano still waiting in the house he left behind.

'Did he ever say why he couldn't?' 'He said performing felt like speaking to a room when the only person he wanted to speak to was gone.'

There were thirty-two pieces.

They were all written for cello and piano.

She sat down.

She was a cellist. Her mother had been a cellist.

He had written thirty-two pieces, over twelve years, for the instrument his wife had played — and for the piano he could no longer perform on publicly.

He had been writing to her mother.

He had been writing to both of them.

The cello part was, by itself, complete — it could be understood as a solo piece.

But she could hear the piano underneath it. It was written to be answered.

She played the whole first piece. She had to stop twice.

Not because of technical difficulty. Because of something else she didn't have a name for yet — something that was not grief exactly, but that sat in the same neighbourhood as grief.

She called Vera.

'I've been playing the cello parts,' she said. 'I can hear the piano. I want to hear it played properly.'

'I thought you would say that,' Vera said.

'I need a pianist. Will you play with me?'

Vera was quiet for a long time. 'Yes. I thought your father might want that.'

'Were you waiting?' 'Yes. I wasn't sure how long it would take.'

'How long since you played chamber music?' 'Several years. But these pieces are for people who know what they're playing about. I think I do.'

The first run-through was slow — both of them learning the other's interpretation, finding where to give and where to hold.

At the end of the first piece, Vera said: 'He wrote this the year after your mother died. The piano part is grieving. The cello is asking questions the piano isn't able to answer yet.' 'How do you know what year?' 'He dated everything.'

Iris looked at her copy of the score. There was a date in the corner she had not seen until now.

Over six weeks, they worked through all thirty-two pieces in chronological order.

In the early pieces, written in the first two years, the music was fractured — technically brilliant but internally discontinuous, like someone writing in a state of shock.

By the middle pieces — years three to seven — something had changed. The writing was more continuous. The cello and piano were in genuine conversation.

'He was coming back,' Vera said.

'Back to what?' 'Back to himself. The music gets quieter as it goes on. Not smaller — more confident.'

The last seven pieces — written in his final three years — were unlike the others.

They were, Iris thought, the most resolved. Not technically the most complex — some of the earlier pieces were harder to play. But these were complete in a different sense.

In the final piece, the piano and cello moved together for the first time without one leading.

'He wrote this about a year before he died,' Vera said.

'How does it feel when you play it?' Iris asked.

'Like something has been settled,' Vera said. 'Like he found the right ending.'

Iris looked at the last page.

'He knew he was writing an ending,' she said. It was not a question.

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With Vera, she begins to speak about music, grief, and what silence held.

After their final rehearsal, Iris went back to her father's house in Wales.

She sat at the Steinway again.

She played the piano part of the last piece — badly, because she was a cellist, not a pianist.

But she played it.

She thought about her father sitting at this piano for twelve years, writing music that no one heard.

She had thought, coming into the house after his death, that the piano represented his loss. She understood now that it was the opposite.

He had kept writing. He had kept the piano tuned. He had been present, in the music, in a way he had not been able to be in any other way.

'I want to perform these,' she said. 'The whole cycle. All thirty-two pieces.'

Vera was quiet. 'That's a significant undertaking,' she said. 'Two evenings at least. Possibly three.'

'I know. I want to do it properly. Will you play?'

'Yes,' Vera said immediately. 'I had been hoping you would decide this. I didn't want to suggest it in case it was too soon.'

'Too soon was twelve years ago,' Iris said. 'We've already waited long enough.'

They rehearsed for four months.

The pieces were, as Iris had expected, difficult — technically and emotionally.

There were several moments in rehearsal when they stopped and could not immediately continue.

Vera, who had been through this kind of work before, said: 'This is part of it. You don't play music like this from a distance. You have to let it reach you, and that takes time to get used to.'

'How do you know when you're ready to perform it?' Iris asked.

'When it reaches you and you can still play,' Vera said. 'That's the difference between rehearsal and performance.' She had not written programme notes before — she was a performer, not a writer.

She wrote three drafts.

The final version said, in part:

My father stopped performing twelve years ago when my mother died. He did not stop writing. These thirty-two pieces were composed in silence, for instruments that played them only in his mind, for an audience of one.

We are performing them for the first time tonight.

She showed the notes to Vera.

'Yes,' Vera said. 'That's right.'

The first evening was at a small concert hall in London — ninety seats.

They had not expected a large audience. The programme was unusual: two unknown performers playing thirty-two pieces by an unknown composer.

Ninety seats were filled.

She had been told that her father had had students, colleagues, people who had known his early career.

She had not understood, until she stood in the wings looking at the filled hall, that his silence had been noticed.

She thought: they came because they knew he had been quiet for a long time, and they wanted to hear what the silence had contained.

She walked on stage. She tuned her cello.

Not technically — there were pieces in the standard repertoire that were harder.

But she had never played in a situation where the music was the answer to a question she had been asking for twelve years, and where the question had been asked not with words but with a silence she had not quite known how to read.

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At last, she returns to the piano and lets feeling become sound.

The last piece — the one where the cello and piano finally moved together without one leading — ended.

The hall was silent for a moment.

Then the audience began to applaud.

Iris did not move immediately. She thought: now I know. colleagues from his performing years.

One woman said: 'I heard him play in 1989. He was extraordinary. I always wondered what happened.'

'He kept writing,' Iris said. 'He just couldn't perform anymore.'

The woman looked at her. 'You played it as if you understood every note.' 'I grew up in its presence,' Iris said. 'I just didn't know it was there.'

After everyone had gone, she sat with Vera in the empty hall.

'He would have been here,' Vera said.

'I know,' Iris said. 'I could feel it.'

A month after the performances, Iris returned to the house in Wales.

She sat at the Steinway again.

She played the opening of the first piece — the piano part, badly, as before.

She thought about twelve years of silence in this room.

She thought about the music that had been written here, heard only in his mind, kept tuned and ready.

She thought: the silence was not an absence. It was full.

She closed the piano lid.

She sat for a while in the quiet room.

Then she drove back to London, with the scores in the passenger seat beside her.

The piano stayed in tune.

stayed in tune akortlu kaldı "The silence was not an absence. It was full." The piano stays in tune. Ready.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. cellist	çellist
2. sensed	hissetmişti
3. lighten	hafifletmek
4. weight	ağırlık
5. particular way	belirli bir şekilde
6. Steinway	Steinway marka piyano
7. in tune	akort
8. maintain	bakımını yapmak
9. scale	gam
10. regularly	düzenli olarak
11. instrument	çalgı
12. ready	hazır
13. scores	notalar, partisyonlar
14. repertoire	repertuvar
15. unspoken rules	söylenmemiş kurallar
16. technically difficult	teknik olarak zor
17. handwritten	el yazısıyla
18. standard repertoire	standart repertuvar
19. address book	adres defteri
20. emeritus	fahri, emekli
21. Royal Academy	Kraliyet Akademisi
22. copies	kopyalar
23. contact	iletişime geçmek
24. expecting	bekliyordu
25. straight-backed	dik duruşlu
26. obligated	yükümlü
27. performing	performans sergilemek
28. compositions	besteler
29. quality of attention	dikkat niteliği
30. thought you might not want	istemeyebileceğini düşündü
31. funeral	cenaze
32. persuade	ikna etmek
33. specificity	kesinlik, özgüllük
34. audience	seyirci, dinleyici
35. the only person	tek kişi
36. was gone	gitmişti
37. spread out	yaydı
38. publicly	kamuoyu önünde

39. immediately	hemen
40. cello	çello
41. written for	... için yazılmış
42. the instrument	enstrüman
43. answered	yanıtlanan
44. solo piece	solo parça
45. neighbourhood of grief	yasın çevresinde
46. by itself	tek başına
47. technical difficulty	teknik güçlük
48. written to be answered	yanıtlanmak üzere yazılmış
49. chamber music	oda müziği
50. know what they're playing about	neyi çaldıklarını bilmek
51. waited	bekledi
52. several years	birkaç yıl
53. properly	düzgünce
54. took time	zaman aldı
55. run-through	prova geçişi
56. interpretation	yorum
57. grieving	yas tutuyor
58. dated everything	her şeyi tarihlendirdi
59. give and hold	vermek ve tutmak
60. corner	köşe
61. chronological order	kronolojik sıra
62. fractured	kırık, parçalı
63. discontinuous	süreksiz
64. genuine conversation	gerçek sohbet
65. state of shock	şok halinde
66. more confident	daha güvenli
67. resolved	çözümlemiş, tamamlanmış
68. technically complex	teknik olarak karmaşık
69. without one leading	birinin öncülüğü olmadan
70. settled	yerleşmiş, çözümlenmiş
71. final piece	son parça
72. complete	eksiksiz
73. badly	kötü şekilde
74. represented	temsil ediyordu
75. the opposite	tam tersi
76. kept writing	yazmaya devam etti

77. kept the piano tuned	piyanonun akordunu korudu
78. present	mevcut, hazır
79. significant undertaking	önemli bir girişim
80. cycle	döngü, seri
81. suggest	önermek
82. perform	sahnelemek, seslendirmek
83. emotionally	duygusal olarak
84. from a distance	uzaktan
85. reach you	sana ulaşmak
86. get used to	alışmak
87. the difference	fark
88. immediately continue	hemen devam etmek
89. programme notes	program notları
90. in part	kısmen
91. composed	bestelendi
92. audience of one	tek kişilik seyirci
93. performing them for the first time	ilk kez seslendirmek
94. three drafts	üç taslak
95. wings	sahne kenarı, kulis
96. filled hall	dolu salon
97. unknown composer	bilinmeyen besteci
98. early career	erken kariyer
99. contained	içerdiği şey
100. filled	dolmuş
101. hundreds of concerts	yüzlerce konser
102. not with words	kelimelerle değil
103. applaud	alkışlamak
104. finally	sonunda
105. know	bilmek
106. question she had been asking	sorduğu soru
107. backstage	sahne arkasında
108. extraordinary	olağanüstü
109. in its presence	onun varlığında
110. performing years	performans yılları
111. colleagues	meslektaşlar
112. I could feel it	hissedebiliyordum
113. opening	açılış, başlangıç
114. piano lid	piyano kapağı

115. passenger seat

yolcu koltuğu

116. absence

yokluk

117. quiet room

sessiz oda

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. cellist

A. çellist

2. repertoire

B. repertuvar

3. compositions

C. besteler

4. chronological

D. kronolojik

5. fractured

E. kırık, parçalı

6. resolved (music)

F. çözümlenmiş

7. undertaking

G. girişim

8. programme notes

H. program notları

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

silence — audience — ready — answered — grieving —
twelve

**1. Her father stopped performing _____ years ago,
when her mother died.**

**2. The piano was still in tune — he had been keeping it
_____ for something.**

**3. Vera said the piano part of the first piece was
_____ while the cello was asking questions.**

4. The cello part was written to be _____ — it needed the piano underneath it.

5. The programme notes said the pieces had been composed in _____, for an audience of one.

6. She realised at the concert that his _____ had been noticed — people came to hear what it contained.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Iris's mother was a pianist. ____

2. Martin stopped composing after his wife died. ____

3. Vera did not know about the compositions until Iris contacted her. ____

4. The thirty-two pieces were written for violin and piano. ____

5. The first performance sells out with ninety seats filled. ____

6. At the end, Iris takes the scores with her when she leaves Wales. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why did Iris not ask her father why he had stopped playing?

8. What surprises Iris about the piano when she sits down at it?

9. What does Martin say to Vera about why he cannot perform?

10. What does Iris realise when she sees the instrumentation of the compositions?

11. What does Vera mean by 'people who know what they're playing about'?

12. How does Vera describe the difference between the early and middle compositions?

13. What does Iris write in the programme notes?

14. What does Iris understand during the final piece in performance?

15. What does the last line mean — 'the piano stayed in tune'?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-A 2-B 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. twelve 2. ready 3. grieving 4. answered 5. silence
6. silence

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. She sensed the silence around the piano was a weight he was carrying in a particular way, and that asking would not lighten it.

8. The piano is still in tune — meaning someone has been maintaining it during the twelve years it was not played.

9. He said performing felt like speaking to a room when the only person he wanted to speak to was gone.

10. All the pieces are for cello and piano — the instrument her mother played. He had been writing to her mother, and to Iris.

11. People who understand the emotional as well as the technical content of the music — who have experienced grief and loss themselves.

12. The early pieces are fractured and discontinuous — written in shock. The middle pieces show genuine conversation between the instruments — he was coming back to himself.

13. That her father composed thirty-two pieces in silence for twelve years, for an audience of one, and that they are being performed for the first time.

14. She understands the answer to the question she had been asking for twelve years about her father's silence.

15. The piano remains maintained and ready — the silence was not emptiness but fullness; his presence in the music continues.